CONNECT DAILY

Wednesday 28 October 2026
themapsproject.com

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- Today's the big one: Chancellor John Healey delivers his first Budget this afternoon, with the OBR's updated Economic and Fiscal Outlook published alongside it.
- Healey has declined to rule tax rises in or out; economists think the fiscal headroom his predecessor built up has likely narrowed, so treat any school-funding figures doing the rounds today as speculation until the statement itself.
- Otherwise a genuinely quiet day - Sheffield schools stay closed for half term until Monday 2 November, and no major new UK schools story broke in the last 24 hours.
- Reminder: the NEU's formal strike ballot over pay, funding and workload is still open and closes 15 December - turnout in the earlier indicative vote was under 50%.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term continues.

28 Oct 2026 — Today: Chancellor John Healey's first Budget, with the OBR's Economic and Fiscal Outlook published alongside it.

15 Dec 2026 — NEU's formal strike ballot over pay, funding and workload closes.

Early 2027 — UK City of Culture 2029 winner announced; Sheffield is one of four finalists.

NATIONAL POLICY & FUNDING

▪ **All eyes on this afternoon's Budget.** Chancellor John Healey - who took the role in July when Andy Burnham became Prime Minister - delivers his first Budget today, with the Office for Budget Responsibility's forecast published alongside it. He has so far declined to confirm or rule out tax rises, and analysts think the fiscal headroom built up by his predecessor has likely shrunk on weaker growth and higher borrowing costs. Nothing is confirmed yet on mainstream or high-needs school funding. (LBC)

→ **For your school:** *Hold off on budget-planning assumptions until this afternoon's statement and the DfE's response to it.*

▪ **NEU ballot still running.** The NEU's formal strike ballot over pay, funding and workload - covering teachers and support staff separately - remains open and closes 15 December. In the earlier indicative ballot, 96% of responding teachers backed rejecting the pay offer and said they'd be prepared to take action, though turnout was under 50%. (NEU)

JARGON-BUSTER - FISCAL HEADROOM

Today's Budget speculation keeps coming back to this phrase.

"Fiscal headroom" is the gap between what the Chancellor plans to spend or borrow and the limit set by the government's own fiscal rules, as judged by OBR forecasts. Less headroom this time around means less room for new spending promises - schools included - without tax rises or cuts elsewhere.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and

why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.